Sense and Sensibility

A simplified retelling

Original story by Jane Austen

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Leaving Norland

When Mr Dashwood died, his house, Norland, passed to his son John. John had promised to help his stepmother and his three half-sisters. But his wife, Fanny, persuaded him that they did not really need his money. Each time they discussed it, the help became smaller, until it almost disappeared.

Elinor Dashwood saw the situation clearly. At nineteen, she often had to think carefully when her mother and younger sisters followed their feelings. Marianne, the middle sister, loved music, poetry and strong emotion. She thought that hiding a feeling made it less sincere.

Before they left, Elinor became close to Fanny’s brother, Edward Ferrars. He was quiet and sometimes awkward, but she valued his kindness. Fanny noticed their friendship and made it clear that Edward was expected to marry money.

An invitation finally offered the Dashwoods a way out. Their cousin, Sir John Middleton, could let them a cottage in Devonshire. They left Norland with less comfort than before, but with a home of their own ahead of them.

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2. Two very different men

At Barton Cottage, Sir John welcomed them warmly. His mother-in-law, Mrs Jennings, loved company and was always trying to discover who might marry whom.

Another visitor, Colonel Brandon, listened quietly when Marianne played the piano. She thought him too old and too serious to understand romance. Elinor noticed the attention he gave her sister, but Marianne dismissed it.

Then Marianne hurt her ankle while walking in the rain. A handsome stranger carried her home. His name was John Willoughby.

He returned to ask about her, and soon he was returning for many other reasons. They liked the same books and music. He spoke eagerly; she answered without hesitation. They went out together so often that the family began to expect an engagement.

Elinor wanted to know what had actually been promised. Marianne felt that such questions made something beautiful sound like business. Surely anyone could see how they felt.

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But feelings, Elinor knew, were not always the same as a clear promise.

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3. A sudden departure

Without warning, Willoughby announced that he had to leave for London. He offered no satisfying explanation. Marianne was miserable. She stopped enjoying the things that had usually made her happy, and she waited anxiously for letters.

Elinor had worries of her own. Edward visited Barton, but he seemed troubled. Sometimes he was affectionate; at other times, he became distant. She could not understand what prevented him from speaking openly.

Later, two young women, Anne and Lucy Steele, came into their circle. Lucy quickly discovered that Elinor knew Edward. She asked for a private conversation and revealed a secret.

She and Edward had been engaged for four years.

Lucy showed Elinor evidence of their relationship and asked her to keep it confidential. Elinor agreed. She had to listen politely while Lucy spoke about the man she loved.

Now Edward’s uncertain behaviour made painful sense.

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Elinor could not tell her family why she was unhappy. She carried on with daily life, quietly making room for a disappointment nobody else could see.

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4. London

Mrs Jennings invited the sisters to London. Marianne agreed eagerly. She could write to Willoughby there and hoped to see him immediately.

Her letters received no answer. When they finally met at a crowded evening gathering, he was cold and uncomfortable. Marianne went towards him with all her usual openness. He barely responded.

Soon a letter arrived. Willoughby denied that he had ever offered her more than friendship. He returned her letters and a lock of her hair. He was going to marry a wealthy woman.

Marianne could hardly believe the words. Elinor stayed beside her and helped her through the first shock.

Colonel Brandon then told Elinor something more serious. He cared for a young woman who had been left under his protection. Willoughby had become involved with her, and she had been abandoned while expecting his child.

The story changed Elinor’s understanding of him. His

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pleasant manner and good taste had concealed a willingness to hurt people when responsibility became inconvenient.

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5. A broken engagement becomes public

Lucy’s secret eventually reached the Ferrars family. Edward’s mother was furious. She demanded that he give Lucy up. When he refused to break his promise, she cut off his financial support and favoured his younger brother, Robert, instead.

Edward did not suddenly stop feeling responsible because his circumstances had changed. Elinor respected that, although it seemed to remove her last hope.

Colonel Brandon offered Edward a position as a clergyman with a modest income. He asked Elinor to pass on the offer. She did so, even though it would make Edward’s marriage to Lucy more possible.

When Marianne finally learned what Elinor had been enduring, she was astonished. She had mistaken her sister’s self-control for a lack of deep feeling.

Elinor explained that remaining considerate did not make the pain disappear. It simply meant that other

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people should not have to suffer because she was suffering.

For the first time, Marianne began to see that quiet strength could be as real as an openly broken heart.

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6. A dangerous illness

On their journey back towards Devonshire, the sisters stayed at Cleveland with friends. Marianne went walking in wet weather and became seriously ill.

The illness worsened. Elinor watched over her through frightening hours. Colonel Brandon went to fetch their mother, and Elinor wondered whether Marianne would live to see her.

During this anxious time, Willoughby arrived. He had heard that Marianne might be dying. He told Elinor that he had truly loved her, but debt and a desire for comfort had led him to marry money. His confession explained his choices without making them less selfish.

Elinor listened, but she did not offer him an easy excuse. He left knowing that regret could not undo what he had done.

Marianne recovered slowly. As she grew stronger, she thought about her own behaviour. She had ignored her health and shut out people who loved her. She wanted to keep her capacity for love without allowing every feeling to control her actions.

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7. Unexpected visitors

Back at Barton, a report arrived that Lucy had married Mr Ferrars. Elinor believed this meant Edward. She tried to accept the news.

Then Edward himself appeared.

Conversation was difficult until someone mentioned his wife. He looked confused. Lucy, he explained, had married his brother Robert. Once Robert had become the wealthy brother, her attachment had changed direction.

Elinor could no longer hold back her feelings. She left the room in tears. Edward had not come to tell her that he was married. He had come because he was free, and because he loved her.

They were finally able to speak honestly. They married and made a modest home together in the parish Colonel Brandon had offered.

Marianne’s feelings changed more gradually. She came to understand Brandon’s kindness, his history and his patience. Eventually, she loved him and married him.

The sisters did not exchange personalities. Marianne still

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felt deeply, and Elinor still thought carefully. But each had learned something from the other about living with both a heart and a mind.

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Words to keep

Inheritance — money or property received after someone dies. John received the family house as his inheritance.

Sincere — honest about what you feel. Marianne wanted every expression of love to be sincere.

Engagement — an agreement to marry. Lucy kept her engagement secret.

Responsibility — something you should take care of. Edward believed his promise was a responsibility.

Self-control — the ability to manage your actions and emotions. Elinor’s self-control did not mean that she felt nothing.

Regret — sadness about something you did or failed to do. Willoughby felt regret after his choices hurt others.

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A question to carry with you

When does showing a feeling help someone understand you? When might pausing before you act help you protect yourself or another person?

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